

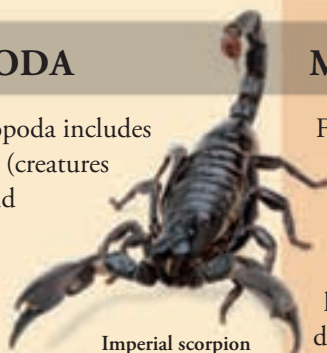
What are invertebrates?

From insects to mollusks, and from worms to jellyfish, invertebrates dominate our planet in terms of their numbers: they make up around 97 percent of the animal kingdom. What features do these animals share in common? Very few! However, they are animals that possess neither a backbone, nor a bony internal skeleton.

Invertebrates are divided into about 30 groups. They include:

ARTHROPODA

The group Arthropoda includes insects, arachnids (creatures such as spiders and scorpions), and crustaceans. Arthropods make up the largest group of invertebrates, and account for about 90 percent of known animal species.



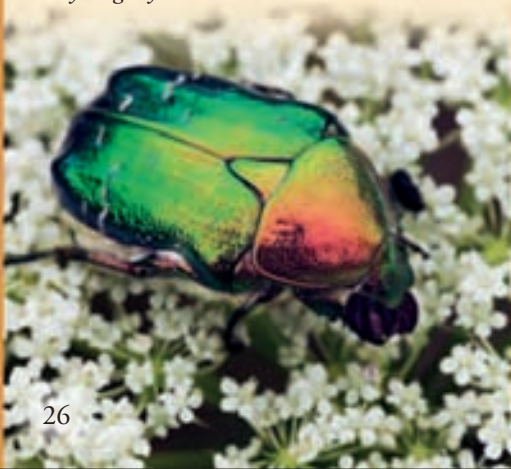
Imperial scorpion



◀ GARDEN CENTIPEDE

A centipede has at least 15 pairs of legs. Centipedes are carnivorous, hunting prey such as insects and spiders.

▼ **ROSE CHAFER BEETLE** *There are more than 300,000 species of beetle, some very brightly colored.*



MOLLUSCA

From a small garden snail to a giant squid, the group that forms Mollusca is incredibly varied. Most mollusks have a shell, or at least the remnants of one, but not all—octopuses have no shell, and neither do slugs.



▲ **NUDIBRANCH** *These marine mollusks are often called "sea slugs." The infant form (larva) has a shell.*

► **GIANT AFRICAN SNAIL** *These are large snails—they can reach 8 in (20 cm) in length.*

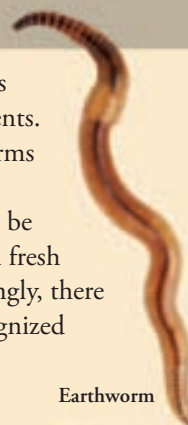


Squid



ANNELIDA

Annelid worms have bodies that are divided into segments. Earthworms and bristleworms are types of annelid worm. Members of this group can be found living in seawater, in fresh water, and on land. Amazingly, there are more than 12,000 recognized species of annelid worm.



Earthworm



▲ **RAGWORM** *These creatures have a pair of swimming legs (called parapods) on each segment of their bodies.*



► **TIGER LEECH** *Some leeches, like this one, will wait for a passing animal and feed off that animal, sucking its blood.*